MOWER MAYHEM

BUDGET TAPE

PUBLISHER	PRICE	MACHINE	CONTROLS
Dalex Software	£1.99	SPECTRUM 128K	Keys

Sunday morning, the grass is up to your knees and Dad has gone to the pub. Over to you. Mower Mayhem hands you an electric Mower and ten walled Lawns, each one a single screen of long grass, red brick flower beds and pink Weeds. Cut as much as you can, zap the Weeds with the Trimmer, and park on the Dock in the bottom corner before the Battery gives out. The catch is the wildlife: a Hedgehog snuffling about, a Cat that dashes across and a Bird that drops in for a peck, and you must never so much as brush one of them. It's a coverage game in the spirit of 3D Painter, with a dash of Boulder Dash route planning, and it takes a little over two minutes to load.



▲ *Hedgehog, Cat, Bird and Mower pose for the family album. Nobody gets hurt.*

GAZ POCKET

"Lovely and twitchy! The Mower turns the instant you touch Q, A, O or P, swings round in a neat arc when you ask for the opposite way, and lines itself up on the stripes so a straight run cuts the whole row. Racing the Battery gauge down to the Dock with the warning going is proper edge-of-the-seat stuff. My moan: a Weed up and to one side can stop the Mower dead, and the Trimmer zaps straight underneath it, so you burn Battery for nothing and have to wriggle free. Once, facing a diagonal, the Weed lit up and my shot still sailed past it. Annoying, but I kept going back. Go on, it's only £1.99."

GP — GAZ SAYS **74%**

PRUE FAIRLEY

"What I like is the kindness of it. The Cat swerves round you, the Hedgehog curls up when cornered, and the Trimmer simply refuses to fire if an animal is in the way, flashing a white "!" on a red square instead. Planning a route round the beds so you finish with Battery to spare is a real puzzle, and a spotless Lawn earns a fat PERFECT LAWN bonus on the tally. By Lawn 10 the garden is crowded with beds and Weeds. Small niggles: against the right wall the warning "!" loses its red box, and the cards flash half-drawn as they come up. Neither spoils it."

PF — PRUE SAYS **70%**



▲ *The Bird drops in for a peck at the long grass. Leave it be.*



▲ *Stuck by a Weed you can't reach: the Trimmer zaps straight underneath it.*



▲ *Every blade cut: that's a PERFECT LAWN and a bonus to match.*

NORM CRABTREE

"I came for the tunes and wasn't let down. On the 128 there's a bouncy title tune, a busy in-game ditty and a jingle for every finished Lawn, a perfect one, Victory and Game Over, and they're a treat. Press M if the family complains. The rest is tidier than I expected: a clear score line, a Battery bar that turns red when it's low, and a pause card that shows whether the music is on. The Mower itself is a bit of a titch on that busy grass, though, and once the novelty of stripes wears off it's the same job ten times over, just with more clutter. Pleasant, not essential."

NC

NORM SAYS **68%**

THE LOWDOWN

CONTROL KEYS	Q A O P to steer (two at once for diagonals), SPACE to trim, H to pause, R to restart from the pause, M for music
USE OF COLOUR	Bright green stripes on dark long grass, red brick beds, pink Weeds and a yellow Dock: no colour clash worth a moan
GRAPHICS	Neat and readable, though the Mower is small and the boxes flash half-drawn as they appear
SOUND	A title tune, an in-game tune and four jingles on the 128, plus plenty of spot effects
SKILL LEVELS	Just the one, but the Lawns fill up with beds and Weeds as you go
SCREENS	Ten one-screen Lawns, all walled in
GENERAL RATING	A gentle, tidy mow-'em-up with a couple of awkward Weeds

VERDICT

Cuts a fine figure for the price, though a few Weeds leave it a little ragged round the edges.

THE RATINGS

PRESENTATION	74%
GRAPHICS	69%
SOUND	80%
PLAYABILITY	70%
ADDICTIVE QUALITIES	70%

OVERALL 71%